

its simplicity, one-click installations, and a wonderful repository, where almost any package can be found.

But then, a couple of months ago, I tried the KDE release of Fedora 12 (code-named Constantine), and I kind of liked it. Although it did not become my permanent distro, I was impressed with its looks, its out-of-the-box support for various hardware, and also with how easy the installation has become. Fedora, as we all know, is a Red Hat-sponsored and community supported project, and is basically the development/testing distribution for Red Hat. When Fedora started off, it was not user-friendly, as a lot of work was terminal-based. But with time, this gap has been filled, and today Fedora can be used by any desktop user.

When I found that the Fedora 13 release was around the corner, I wanted to try it out. Given my good experience with Constantine, I could not wait till Goddard's final release. So I downloaded the Fedora 13 Beta version, positive that it should be better than Constantine. As a beta version, I knew there would be many bugs, and the road might not be smooth. I burnt the image onto a DVD and popped it into my drive to explore. Here is a recap of my experience with Fedora 13 Beta.

Hardware:

- Intel Core 2 Duo 2.0 GHz processor
- 2 GB RAM
- 160 GB hard drive

Installation problems

Booting from the DVD, I was greeted with quite a number of options to choose from: install a new system or upgrade, install system with basic video drivers, rescue install system, boot from local drive and memory test. I chose the first option, and was greeted by the anaconda installer 13.37.2. Since it was a GUI installer, installation was not difficult.

I was prompted with screens for language selection, time-zone selection, hard drive location, password, package selection and more—I chose the appropriate options, and kept clicking Next till I made it to the disk partitioning screen. This is the most crucial part in any installation, to prevent loss of existing data on the hard disk. I carefully read through the screen, and chose to do a custom partitioning. I created a 20 GB partition with the ext3 file system for my root (/) file-system. I also created a 1 GB swap partition. I saved changes, and clicked Next, to begin the actual installation. Formatting of partitions was followed by installation of packages into the hard drive, taking a total of 45 minutes for the installation.

Once installation was over, the system prompted me to reboot. On reboot, though, I was presented with a black screen—no GRUB :-(. Since this was a beta version, I was not surprised. I booted the system from the install DVD again, and tried upgrading it (not a fresh installation), and that worked. GRUB was installed, and I was able to boot the system. During installation, I chose to do custom package selection, and installed both the GNOME and KDE desktop environments. Since I use GNOME, I'll focus more on my GNOME experience.

Category	Applications
Accessories	Archive Manager, Calculator, Character Map, Dictionary, gedit Text Editor, GNote, Passwords and Encryption Keys, Take Screenshot
Games	AisleRiot Solitaire, Iagno, Mines, Sudoku
Graphics	GIMP, Shotwell Photo Manager, Simple Scan
Internet	Empathy IM client, Firefox, Remote Desktop Viewer, Transmission Torrent Client
Office	Evolution Mail and Calendar, OpenOffice.org Calc, Draw, Impress and Writer, Project management
Other	Release Notes
Sound & Video	Audio CD Extractor, Brasero Disk Burner, Cheese Webcam Booth, Movie Player, Rhythmbox Music Player

Table 1: Default applications in Fedora 13



Figure 1: Default GNOME screen after first boot

GNOME experience

Fedora's GNOME desktop has the 'Computer', 'Home folder' and 'Trash' icon on the desktop (Figure 1). The look and feel of the distro has improved, but not changed much from Fedora 12. GNOME 2.29.92 is used in the beta version, while the final release will have GNOME 2.30.

The first thing I noticed was that my Internet connection was configured automatically, and I could browse without any glitches. The default browser is Mozilla 3.6.2—and as usual, there's no built-in support